▼ GLASSHOUSE



STRIKING A CHORD

When Congress leader **Rahul Gandhi** landed in Assam on October 17 to pay tribute to the late **Zubeen Garg**, nearly a month after the singer's death in Singapore, the visit hit a few political side notes of its own. Chief Minister **Himanta Biswa Sarma** wasted no time taking a jab, saying Rahul had arrived "28 days too late" and accused the Congress of indifference toward Assam, alleging that "no big leader" had come when Bharat Ratna Bhupen Hazarika had died in 2011 as well. Within hours, however, the internet dug out Himanta's own post from his Congress days, featuring a photograph of Rahul paying his respects to Hazarika. Rahul, for his part, stayed clear of politics. At Zubeen's home, he said he understood why the musician called himself Kanchenjunga. "Like the Kanchenjunga, Zubeen was honest, transparent, unshakeable and beautiful," he said. Try finding fault with that!

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ MAMATA'S DIVINE PUSH

HOLY HEIGHTS

Like many of her counterparts in the north, West Bengal CM **Mamata Banerjee** seems to have caught the 'temple bug'. After unveiling the Jagannath shrine in Digha, she's now promising a Mahakal temple in Siliguri, complete with the "tallest Shiva idol". Predictably, with elections just a year away, the Opposition is furious, but for different reasons. The Congress and Left are accusing her of using public money to woo the electorate while main rivals BJP are upset that the Trinamool leader has stolen a march on them, for surely they have the proprietary right to erect the tallest and biggest temples. But the BJP can't complain openly. Meanwhile, Siliguri residents have little say on where the ginormous Shiva statue will come up. The political higher-ups will decide that.

